

Diabetic Eye Disease - NIDDK

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Diabetic Eye Disease - NIDDK Home Health Information Diabetes Diabetes Overview Preventing Diabetes Problems Diabetic Eye Disease Related Topics English English Espa#241;ol Diabetic Eye Disease On this page: What is diabetic eye disease? How does diabetes affect my eyes? How common is diabetic eye disease? Who is more likely to develop diabetic eye disease? What are the symptoms of diabetic eye disease? When should I see a doctor right away? How do doctors diagnose eye problems from diabetes? How do doctors treat diabetic eye disease? What can I do to protect my eyes? What if I already have some vision loss from diabetes? What is diabetic eye disease? Diabetic eye disease is a group of eye problems that can affect people with diabetes. These conditions include diabetic retinopathy, diabetic macular edema, cataracts, and glaucoma. Over time, diabetes can cause damage to your eyes that can lead to poor vision or even blindness. But you can take steps to prevent diabetic eye disease, or keep it from getting worse, by taking care of your diabetes. The best ways to manage your diabetes and keep your eyes healthy are to manage your blood glucose , blood pressure , and cholesterol , sometimes called the diabetes ABCs If you smoke, get help to quit smoking have a dilated eye exam once a year Photo courtesy of the National Eye Institute, NIH. Your eyes may seem fine, but having a full, dilated eye exam is the only way to know for sure. Often, there are no warning signs of diabetic eye disease or vision loss when damage first develops. A full, dilated eye exam helps your doctor find and treat eye problem

How do doctors treat diabetic eye disease? Your doctor may recommend having eye exams more often than once a year, along with management of your diabetes. This means managing your diabetes ABCs, which include your A1c, blood pressure, and cholesterol; and quitting smoking. Ask your health care team what you can do to reach your goals. Management of blood glucose can help prevent diabetic eye disease and keep it from getting worse. Doctors may treat advanced eye problems with medicine, laser treatments, surgery, or a combination of these options. Medicine Your doctor may treat your eyes with anti-VEGF medicine, such as aflibercept, bevacizumab, or ranibizumab. These medicines block the growth of abnormal blood vessels in the eye. Anti-VEGF medicines can also stop fluid leaks, which can help treat diabetic macular edema . The doctor will inject an anti-VEGF medicine into your eyes during office visits. You'll have several treatments during the first few months, then fewer treatments after you finish the first round of therapy. Your doctor will use medicine to numb your eyes so you don't feel pain. The needle is about the thickness of a human hair. Anti-VEGF treatments can stop further vision loss and may improve vision in some people. Laser Treatment Laser treatment, also called photocoagulation, creates tiny burns inside the eye with a beam of light. This method treats leaky blood vessels and extra fluid, called edema. Your doctor usually provides this treatment during several office visits, using medicine to numb your eyes. Laser treatment can keep eye disease from getting worse, which is important to prevent vision loss or blindness. But laser treatment is less likely to bring back vision you've already lost compared with anti-VEGF medicines. There are two types of laser treatment : Focal/grid laser treatment works on a small area of the retina to treat diabetic macular edema. Scatter laser treatment, also called panretinal photocoag